



Healing: The Unburdening Process

While we encourage therapists to try working with protective parts using the 6F's (find, focus, fleshout, feel toward, befriend and explore fears), we discourage therapists from trying to unburden exiled parts without more formal IFS training (for example, an IFS level 1, which are listed at www.selfleadership.org).

Pursuing an unburdening without the appropriate skill level would not be respectful of the client's already fragile system and can easily backfire by causing protectors to mistrust you. If an exile does arise in your work, we encourage you to do whatever you normally do when working with such vulnerability.

However we do illustrate the steps of unburdening below so the reader has an overarching view and is completely informed about the IFS model of therapy. Those who wish to learn to do unburdenings can pursue IFS experientially, in therapy and training.

UNBURDENING AFTER WITNESSING

Healing is set in motion as soon as protectors allow the Self to be in relationship with exiled parts. We may know that access has been granted because the client is suddenly seeing events from the past, or the client may make a more formal agreement with protectors to step back and let the Self see the exile's experiences. When clients are "in Self" you see a shift: their voice gets softer, their body relaxes and their perspective becomes more open and expansive. In either case, as illustrated throughout this manual, we call this step in IFS therapy "witnessing."

During witnessing, an exiled part takes the Self on a tour and the rising memories may surprise the client, who had dismissed or forgotten what the part is showing. The part may show an event that signifies a long pattern of abusive, exploitive or neglectful interactions or it may show a moment of betrayal or terror. In either case, the events it shows will have led to negative consequences (frightening bodily sensations, negative feelings and negative beliefs about safety and self-worth) that need to be disconfirmed in the relationship between the Self and the part. During witnessing, exiled parts have the client's Self with them (compassion), and they may

need the client's Self to feel some portion of what they are feeling (empathy), but they are also aware of and need compassion from the therapist too.

THE UNBURDENING PROCESS

1. **WITNESS:** The exiled part shows the Self about its experience.
2. **DO-OVER:** The Self comes into that time and space, and gives the part what it needed and wanted at the time but never got.
3. **RETRIEVE:** The Self retrieves the part from the past and brings it somewhere safe in the present.
4. **UNBURDEN:** The part lets go of toxic sensations, feeling states and beliefs.
5. **INVITE:** The part invites any new qualities it wants or needs for the future.
6. **PROTECTOR CHECK-IN:** Protectors are invited to notice that the part they protected has been unburdened and healed so they can let go of their jobs.

WITNESS

Exiled parts are often shocked to meet the Self. "If you exist, why have I been suffering like this?" In which case, apologies and patience are in order. Once the part feels ready to connect it begins to show and tell the Self about terrifying, shaming, injuring experiences that burdened it and the inner system with toxic beliefs. During witnessing, we ask the client: "Do you see yourself with the exile or are you there?" If the former, a Self-like part has stepped in and we ask that part to let the client's Self take over.

DO-OVER

If the part is stuck in a bad situation, the Self offers to come in and do what the part needed someone to do at the time (restrain an adult, speak up to others, hold the part, love the part, or whatever it requests). Rescripting a traumatic moment with a preferred outcome is very important for some parts. They do not, of course, forget what happened, but the process seems to be validating and emotionally significant.

RETRIEVE

Finally, when the exile signals that its needs have been met and witnessing feels complete, the client's Self invites the exile to leave the past and come with it to the present time in a safe place of its choice.

UNBURDEN

Once the exiled part is safe in the present with the client's Self, we invite it to release any physical sensations, feelings, or thoughts it carries related to the trauma. Here we usually follow the client's lead but if the client asks, we offer suggestions like throwing burdens in the ocean, burning them in a fire or releasing them to the air. (e.g., If it wants, the part could give this burden up to light, earth, air, water or fire.)

INVITE

When the exile lets go of burdens it has more space internally. One of the last healing steps is to instruct the part to invite in any qualities it has been missing. The reply to this very general instruction almost always includes positive qualities that relate to Self-energy, along the lines of love, play, joy, spontaneity, courage, connectedness and creativity.

PROTECTOR CHECK-IN

Once the exile is healed, we invite protective parts to come in and take a look at the part. They often spontaneously let go of their protective role because they see that the part is safe in the presence of the client's Self. In trauma it is common for protective parts to carry their own burdens, which will need to be addressed during a follow-up session.

TRANSFORM

During the process of the Self witnessing, redoing, retrieving, unburdening, inviting and reintegrating vulnerable parts, they are transformed and healed, which gives the whole inner system an opportunity to grow spacious and strong.

THE STEPS OF THE UNBURDENING PROCESS

Hetta came to therapy because she wanted to have children but had overwhelming anxiety about being pregnant. In this interchange she has gotten permission from her protectors to help a 7-year-old exile.

HETTA: She's so surprised to see me. She's saying, "Where have you been?"

Befriend

THERAPIST: What do you say?

- *Checking for Self-energy.*

HETTA: I'm telling her I'm sorry I left her alone.

- *Hetta has access to Self-energy.*

THERAPIST: What does she say?

HETTA: She's saying if she didn't deserve it, why did I do it?

THERAPIST: What do you say?

- *Letting Hetta's Self take the lead.*

HETTA: I wasn't there. I'm really sorry. But I'm here now.

THERAPIST: How does she respond?

HETTA: She's looking at me. She wonders if she can trust me.

THERAPIST: What's it been like for her to be without you?

- *Helping to keep defensive parts from taking over and avoid telling the part what to feel by orienting the client toward witnessing.*

As this vignette illustrates, in IFS we focus on repairing the relationship between the part and the client's Self until the part feels understood and validated.

Witnessing

When the repair is sufficient and the exile has confidence in the Self, the part will begin a virtual tour to show the Self whatever it needs to have witnessed. The witnessing interlude is a kind of bonding and de-shaming (validating) process for the exiled part. Once

witnessing is in flow we want to continue until the part is satisfied that the Self understands and the part is ready to unload its burdens. This may require more than one session. Let's continue with this example. Hetta sees the 7-year-old in a hospital room.

HETTA: This is before she had heart surgery. Her mother is crying in the hall with a nurse. Someone walking by in the hall says, "That's the one!" and she thinks it means she's the one who's going to die.

THERAPIST: What is that like for her?

- *Witnessing.*

HETTA: Where is her father?

THERAPIST: He's not there?

HETTA: No. He never came.

THERAPIST: Can she feel you there with her?

- *Checking on the Self-to-part connection.*

HETTA: We're walking around the hospital. She hates the smell. She's telling me not to have children because we'll end up back in a hospital and die.

THERAPIST: What do you say?

- *Handing the baton to the client's Self.*

HETTA: I can see why she's worried. I'm telling her that I trust my doctor. I'm asking her if she can trust me. She's also afraid if something is wrong with my child I will leave like dad did.

Witnessing

THERAPIST: What does she want you to know about that?

HETTA: She misses her real dad.

THERAPIST: Do you understand what she means?

HETTA: Yeah. He was there when I got home but he didn't seem like my real dad anymore.

A Do-Over

THERAPIST: Is there anything she needs you to say to him now that she needed someone to say at the time?

HETTA: She wants him to apologize.

THERAPIST: What does she want you to say to him?

- *The part directs.*

HETTA: You should have loved your daughter better than that....

THERAPIST: What's happening?

HETTA: He says he's sorry. He does love her. He was afraid. She won't forgive him now but she's glad he apologized.

THERAPIST: Does she need anything else to happen with him – or anyone else?

- *The part directs.*

HETTA: Not now.

THERAPIST: Can you give her what she needed back then?

HETTA: Yes she needed to be loved. I'm doing that now and she really likes it.

Retrieval

THERAPIST: Is she ready to leave that time and place?"

HETTA: Yes.

THERAPIST: Bring her somewhere safe in the present time. What's it like for her to be with you now?

HETTA: She likes it. I'm showing her around. I'm asking if she could trust me to take care of a child, even if that child had a problem.

As we see, initiating therapy helped Hetta find a part who felt abandoned in a lonely, terrifying moment. After having had heart surgery, Hetta recovered and her post-surgery

parts, eager to look forward and be active, had minimized this experience of illness, fear, anger and imminent death. After Hetta's Self validated her experience of the illness and abandonment and spoke up for her with her father she was ready to leave the past.

Unburdening

THERAPIST: Now that she's with you in the present, is she ready to let go of all the thoughts, feelings and sensations she got from that experience?

- *Inviting the part to let go of fear and toxic beliefs.*

HETTA: Yes.

THERAPIST: Have her show you where they are – in, on or around her body.

- *Deepening the experience.*

HETTA: She has pins in her heart.

THERAPIST: What does she want to do with them?

- *The part directs.*

HETTA: She's pulling them out and sticking them in the ground... that let everything out.

THERAPIST: Everything?

HETTA: Anger, sadness. It's blowing away.

The Invitation

THERAPIST: With that gone, what would she like to invite in?

HETTA: Strength. Energy. Play!

THERAPIST: How's she doing now?

HETTA: Really good. She looks so peaceful and at ease. That's amazing!

THERAPIST: Invite her protectors to come and take a look. Let them know she is safe with you now. Do any of them have anything to say?

HETTA: Yes, they like it.

THERAPIST: Do any of them need your help with feeling stuck or carrying burdens?

HETTA: I think they do.

THERAPIST: That makes sense. Let them know we'll come back to them next week.

Meanwhile, do they need a safe place to be?

HETTA: No, they're okay.

THERAPIST: Will they let you take care of the 7-year-old?

HETTA: Yes. They're okay with that.



Once Hetta's exiled 7-year-old feels understood and validated, and her fears have been addressed, she is willing to trust Hetta's Self and let go of her burdens. At the end of her unburdening, the therapist invites the parts who have protected her to notice what has happened and speak up about any further concerns as well as their own needs.

As Hetta's unburdening illustrates, IFS is a transformational model. Once protectors allow the client's Self to have a relationship with an exile, the Self witnessing the exile's experience heals attachment wounds. When the exile is ready to leave the past, retrieving it formalizes the client's mental shift to the present, which liberates protectors. Finally, unburdening illustrates both the ways in which frightening experiences and oppressive beliefs ("I'm unlovable, I'm worthless") grip the body ("I have pins in my heart") and the wonderfully antithetical benefits of feeling securely attached in the present with the Self.

STEP-BY-STEP BUT NOT ALWAYS LINEAR

As we move through these steps, from befriending protectors to witnessing and unburdening exiles, we can only be as linear as the client's system allows us to be. As we get close to an exile, we expect protectors to get activated. If this happens, the therapist's Self usually steps in to explore their fears, offer reassurance and negotiate a way forward.

LETTING GO: THE MOMENT OF TRANSFORMATION

After the Self witnesses the exiled part's traumatic experiences and the exile is safely in the present, the Self invites the part to let go of traumatic body sensations, toxic beliefs and extreme feeling states. We invite the exile to choose how it wants to let go, and we often suggest choosing one of the elements (light, earth, air, water, fire), an option that unfolded organically over the years as IFS therapists stayed with the wishes of clients' internal systems, which is consistent with the traditions of Shamanism. Letting go is the ceremonial endpoint to the whole process of unburdening. Before proceeding, we make sure all burdens are gone.

WHAT NEXT FOR EXILES?

After unburdening we invite exiles to bring in desired qualities that have been blocked by burdens. Most often they name something in the ballpark of the usual C (curiosity, calm, clarity, connectedness, confidence, courage, creativity and compassion) or P (presence, patience, persistence, perspective, playfulness) words: "I want to play," "I want to be creative," "I want courage," "I want love."

FOLLOWING UP WITH PROTECTORS

After an unburdening is complete, we check with protectors. Did they watch? How do they feel now? Are they ready to retire or retool and have a new job? Sometimes they are ready to change and sometimes they wait to see how things will go before giving up their jobs entirely. But they will in any case express relief and be more relaxed. If the unburdening wasn't complete or (down the road) if a burden comes back, they will stay vigilant.

WHAT NEXT FOR PROTECTORS?

If protective parts are relieved after watching the unburdening and feel ready for change, we ask what they would rather do. Often a protector will choose the opposite of what it has been doing. For example, a critic will want to cheerlead or a cautious part will want to encourage the client to explore. But some hard-working protectors just want a break. In addition, especially in clients with trauma histories, some protectors hold their own burdens and will need help to unload what they carry. Once protective parts have released their burdens or let go of the job they held, their

wishes can be surprising. A protector of one client declared its wish to go sailing, at which she burst out laughing and said, “Where on earth did that come from? I don’t like boats. I don’t even like to swim.”

POST UNBURDENING: FUTURE SESSIONS

In the weeks after an unburdening we often hear clients describe various sensory analogs for release like “light,” “fizzing” or “serene,” and when the client checks in she finds the unburdened part is playing or otherwise happily engaged. We also often hear spontaneous reports from clients who feel what we consider to be unblended and more Self-led: he finds he is calmer; she finds she has more confidence, etc. Whatever liberated protectors have chosen to do, we return to check on their needs and we also ask the client to check in with the unburdened part daily for three or four weeks because this seems to be the time internal systems require to integrate and consolidate change.

WHEN BURDENS RETURN

But obstacles can arise and burdens can be taken back. This is most likely to happen when:

1. A crisis occurs in the client’s life right after an unburdening, which frightens protectors.
2. A protector who did not give permission for the unburdening actively undermines it.
3. Lack of follow up by client during the week causes the part to once again feel abandoned.
4. The exiled part did not share its whole story.
5. The burden was not fully understood by the Self.
6. Another part within the system is using the burden.

A BURDEN RETURNING

THERAPIST: Will you check-in briefly every day with that part you just healed?

ZACH: I’ll try my best.

THERAPIST: What might get in the way?

- *“I’ll try my best” is an ambivalent enough response to raise a red flag.*

ZACH: I get busy.

THERAPIST: How about setting a time? When you wake up or go to sleep? It’s really important to strengthen this new bond between you and him. It takes about 3 weeks to solidify.

- *We emphasize the importance of checking in with parts who have unburdened for at least three weeks afterward.*

ZACH: Okay I can do that.

One Week Later

THERAPIST: Let’s check in with the teenage boy you helped last week.

ZACH: I had a bad week. My wife and I got a call from my son’s principal. They caught him smoking pot at a school dance. We had a series of meetings and he got suspended. We had to come up with consequences at home. Honestly, I really didn’t have time to check in with that kid.

THERAPIST: What happened with Josh does sound preoccupying. Let’s check in with your teenager and see how he’s doing. Is he still in the present with you on the beach?

ZACH: I can’t really tell. I don’t see him anymore.

THERAPIST: Take a little time and check around for him inside.

- *If an exile has been dropped after an unburdening, be persistent, follow up and reestablish the connection.*

ZACH: I think he’s back in my childhood bedroom.

THERAPIST: Ask him what happened.

ZACH: He got scared about what was happening between Josh and me.

Witnessing

THERAPIST: Would he share more about that?

ZACH: I was mad at Josh. He says I was acting a lot like my father so he left.

THERAPIST: Does that make sense to you?

ZACH: Yeah. Now that he points it out. My dad got mad a lot when I was young and we really didn't talk about that last week.

- *Zach is now getting some space from his “dad” part who was rejecting his own teenager as well as his son.*

THERAPIST: Sometimes a wound reopens because the part loses the connection with you or sometimes the part didn't get to share everything. It sounds like a little of both happened for him.

Repairing

ZACH: I see that now. I'm apologizing to him. I don't actually want to act like my dad.

THERAPIST: Would it be okay to hear more from him about your father's anger?

ZACH: Yes.



We recommend assessing how things are going for the client and the relevant parts after an unburdening. When a burden returns, we'll find out one way or another because it will effect the client negatively. The sooner we catch any problems, the better.

We will not offer any exercises in this manual for unburdening exiles because we urge you to do whatever you typically do with vulnerability if you come across an exile. To learn the steps that help an exile unburden, seek formal training in IFS therapy.

THE SCIENCE OF UNBURDENING EXILES AND HEALING WOUNDS

Exiled parts are wounded, vulnerable and often young. They carry burdens from experiences that terrify, shame or exploit – sometimes all three. With their burdensome feelings and beliefs, they are heavy and threatening to the internal system. But without these burdens they are playful, creative and life-affirming. We believe that exiled parts, like protectors, live in the mind and utilize unintegrated neural networks in the brain. In addition, exiles primarily live within implicit memory (unconscious, tenacious, emotional and without a cohesive narrative). The healing of trauma starts in the mind when we access the imagination, a powerful neuroplastic agent (Doidge, 2007), and continues as we convert implicit to explicit memory so the brain can integrate dysregulated neural networks.

The unburdening process allows exiled parts to let go, release their pain, feel whole again and reintegrate with the inner system of parts. This process seems consistent with memory reconsolidation, a form of neuroplasticity that changes existing emotional memory at the synaptic level (Ecker, 2012). Memory reconsolidation includes four phases: accessing, reactivation, mismatch and erasure.

- 1) In the accessing phase of memory reconsolidation the client identifies and retrieves implicit emotional memory. In IFS, we do this when we help the client find, focus on and flesh out a target part.
- 2) In the reactivation phase the emotional memory network is destabilized, which renders it susceptible to being unlocked at the synaptic level. In IFS we are doing this when we help a target part unblend and connect with the client's Self instead of simply reliving its experience.
- 3) The mismatch phase involves a full disconfirmation of the meaning of the target memory. In IFS we believe the mismatch unfolds as the exiled part feels fully understood, validated and loved by the Self during witnessing, the do-over and retrieval steps, all crucial for healing.
- 4) In the last phase of erasure the client has the opportunity to revise the meaning of traumatic experience with new learning. Along these lines in IFS, exiles revise their history by letting old meanings go (unburdening toxic sensations, feelings and beliefs) and inviting in new qualities they need. Of course, memory reconsolidation, like IFS therapy, does not cause people to forget the past. It does, however, change their current emotional experiencing when they recall traumatic events.

Counteractive change, the principal strategy of cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), focuses on creating new networks to compete with old ones while memory reconsolidation on the other hand, reorganizes the original neural network at the synaptic level (Ecker, 2012). We believe the unburdening process in IFS, through the process of memory reconsolidation, heals traumatic wounds at their core.

LEGACY BURDENS

When we speak of “burdens” we mean ongoing negative feeling states (shame, terror, etc.) and beliefs (I’m unlovable, I’m worthless, I’m bad, etc.) that originated in the past. In IFS, legacy burdens are similar but are inherited through family and culture. They can develop in two ways:

- Overtly during interactions with caretakers (often parents or other relatives who may be important in a child’s life): an overt legacy burden is created when the caretaker’s protector treats the child’s parts the way it treats parts of its own internal system (Sinko, 2016).
- Covertly by way of contagion in family and culture: covert legacy burdens are created because children are highly susceptible to the feelings and beliefs of their parents (Sinko, 2016).

THE ORIGINS OF LEGACY BURDENS

A legacy burden often derives from a feeling state that is strongly expressed by a parent or in a family (for example, anxiety), which may or may not come with articulated beliefs (e.g., foreign travel is dangerous) but to which no instructive story is attached. A legacy burden can also derive from the group experience (including the experiences of perpetrators) of one’s ancestors, like genocide, slavery, famine or war.

While exiles carry burdens (like “I’m worthless”) and tend to be eager for help, and protectors have their own kind of burdens (their jobs are burdensome), which they release along with the exile, a legacy burden is systemic and is held in place either by its invisibility (“it’s always been this way”) or by loyalty. Legacy burdens, like personal burdens, may derive from mundane misattunements of childhood or from more obviously traumatic events, but they are inherited. Legacy burdens are feelings, beliefs, energy, and behavior whose origins hail from the lives of our ancestors. As a result, legacy burdens can have the generalized, indeterminate quality of

family habit and family rules. When the burdening event was seen as shameful and was kept secret at the time, the story is particularly likely to have become “unknown, unrecoverable, vague, or (like the game ‘telephone’) significantly distorted”(Sinko, 2016, p. 173).

LOYALTY AND LEGACY

Loyalty to caregivers and siblings, family and culture can put a powerful lock on burdens in the client’s system, which then governs everything from her choice of partner and work to her health and way of dying (Sinko, 2016).

EPIGENETICS

Recent discoveries in the field of epigenetics also tell us that PTSD is a genetically-inherited disorder, which can be passed down to offspring from either parent (Burri, et al, 2013). IFS has long recognized the intergenerational transmission of trauma in legacy burdens.

HOW LEGACY BURDENS DIFFER FROM PERSONAL BURDENS

Like other burdens, we may hear about a legacy burden at any point. That said, we often discover legacy burdens when protectors are particularly uncooperative and the client’s system seems stuck or when a regular unburdening doesn’t last. The legacy burden can be carried anywhere in the system, so it may not be carried by an exile. And once the client recognizes that a burden is inherited and not personal, protectors usually want to let it go (Sinko, 2016). If this does not happen and protectors are instead reluctant to let a legacy burden go, we recommend exploring concerns that relate to family loyalty, which is likely to be a factor.

A LEGACY BURDEN

THERAPIST: You keep mentioning that feelings weren’t allowed in your family. Are you interested in exploring this more?

NADINE: Sure, it’s the way it was – and still is for that matter.

THERAPIST: Go inside and see what comes up for you about feelings not being allowed.

NADINE: I'm seeing my mother telling me not to feel this or that.

- *A part begins to show its experience to her.*

THERAPIST: Does one particular situation rise to the top?

NADINE: There was a general message from her that feelings are not useful, get in the way and should be pushed away so we can always keep moving forward. That's how it was in my family. As an adult I see how harmful it was.

- *We call this kind of family culture a legacy burden.*

THERAPIST: It sounds like this was her belief and it influenced you and your brother in negative ways. Is that right?

NADINE: Definitely.

THERAPIST: Do you need this belief?

NADINE: No!

THERAPIST: Would you like to unload it?

NADINE: I didn't realize I could! It's inside me. It's like cellular. I'd love to change that.

THERAPIST: You can release it. I'll show you how.

NADINE: Great! Let's do it.

THERAPIST: Focus on the part or parts who believe that feelings are bad and you shouldn't have them.

NADINE: It's not just one part. It's like ... interstitial.

THERAPIST: Does any of it belong to your system?

NADINE: No it belongs to my mother.

THERAPIST: Using your mind's eye, ask your mother if the belief belongs to her.

NADINE: She says it came from her mother.

THERAPIST: Okay. Do they want to share anything with you about this belief?

NADINE: They're both saying it's just the role of women in our family. We are supposed to ignore hardship and keep moving forward.

THERAPIST: Does this make sense to you?

NADINE: Yeah! It's the female cross to bear in my family.

THERAPIST: Well now you have a choice. Knowing it doesn't belong to you, do you want to release it?

NADINE: I am totally ready to unload this. I don't want to live this way for another minute.

THERAPIST: Okay. Find the belief, in or around your body. Got it? What does it look like?

NADINE: It is armor – a metal chest plate. It's medieval actually!

THERAPIST: How do you want to let it go?

NADINE: I'm letting it sink to the bottom of the sea – for crabs and fish to live in.



Nadine's system was willing to let this legacy burden go, which is often—but not always—the case. The best tactic is simply to ask if the client's system is ready to unload a legacy burden. If it is not, then we can spend the time to address fears and uncover the ties that bind.

Exercise

FIND YOUR LEGACY BURDENS

DIRECTIONS: Create a family genogram that includes as much as you know (or can find out) about your extended family. There are free online websites that offer a variety of options for types of genograms (for example, <http://www.genopro.com/Default-New.aspx>).

In your genogram:

- Highlight trauma in general and note specific issues you want to track like alcohol, divorce, domestic violence, incest, multiple childbirths, unsafe living conditions, slavery, racism, substance abuse, war, genocide, starvation, immigration, and the like.
- Also include the positive, such as particular gifts and talents: musical, good at math, mechanical, relationally skilled.

For example:

My maternal grandparents:

- Mary
 - Grew up in New York city, daughter of immigrants from Ireland who worked in factories, alcoholic father, 10 siblings, 2 died in infancy.
- Colin
 - Grew up in upstate New York, the son of a plumber and a housewife who had a “nervous breakdown” when Colin was 10 years old.
- Their children
 - My mother, Sybil
 - Aunt Eleanor
 - Uncle Edward (died accidentally at 15 years old)

My parents:

- Sybil: school teacher
- Joseph: accountant
 - My siblings and me
 - ◊ Me
 - ◊ Liam: housepainter, alcohol problem, 1 child

◇ Marie: nurse, 2 children

Aunt Eleanor: gave up ambition to be an opera singer

- Her husband Al: car mechanic

- My cousins

◇ Sharon: talented singer, no children

◇ Dale: works as an actuary, 3 children

Notice repeating patterns of strength and vulnerability in the ancestral map and write them down below, use extra paper as needed.

Strengths:

Vulnerabilities:

Choose an ancestral vulnerability that also resides in you and has influenced your life.

- Turn your attention inside and ask permission to pay attention to this vulnerability.
- If there are concerns, listen to them and either set an intention to return to this with the help of a therapist or, if you get permission, proceed.
- Notice the vulnerability in, on or around your body.

- Ask the following question and write down what you hear without censoring or thinking:

- What percentage of this vulnerability belongs to me, and what percentage belongs to my parents (or someone else from your early life)?

_____ % belongs to me.

_____ % belongs to _____.